

popular decisions—will have terrible consequences for anyone in power. In such a context, he is willing to wait in the wings for his chance.

Many believe that Zardari too was left with no choice but to make his move against Sharif, now that Musharraf was out of the picture. Of course, Zardari would have preferred that Sharif continued in the Government, to shoulder some of the flak that it is bound to get in the coming months. But he had also been stung by the talk that his junior coalition partner was setting the agenda for him. "Nawaz has proved that his is an

while in Government, Sharif was never willing to commit himself to what he saw as America's and Musharraf's war. The US too was suspicious of Sharif's allegiances, given his past proximity to the religious lobby.

Zardari has other reasons to push for his own shot at the presidency. Once President, he would be in a position where the PPP controls all levers of power. It already has its prime minister, the National Assembly speaker and deputy speaker as well as stable gov-

BACK TO THE STREETS: Lawyers are gearing up for more protests

last the current Parliament.

On a personal level, Zardari also stands to gain from the presidential indemnity that accrues to the office of the President. As long as he remains in office, Zardari cannot be proceeded against in a court of law, a stipulation that would come in handy even if the November 2 judiciary is restored and it strikes down the NRO. Though it is unlikely that deposed Chief Justice Iftikhar Chaudhary would immediately take on Zardari if he is restored, as far as the PPP leader is concerned, it is better to be safe than sorry. But even if Zardari wins the presidency on

September 6, which looks increasingly likely given the support of parties such as the Muttahida Qaumi Movement, the Awami National Party and Jamiat-e-Ulema-e-Islam-Fazlur Rahman, he may find that it is a bitter victory.

After receiving kudos for holding the party together and showing statesmanship in the wake of Benazir's assassination, Zardari's personal popularity is once again in the doldrums. In public perception he is once again being painted as "evil incarnate". The issue of the judiciary will continue to haunt him as will the perception that his word is not to be trusted. The PPP Government

has already restored eight of the Sindh High Court judges by re-appointing them, but it is a move that has drawn flak from the lawyers' movement and the PML(N) which sees this as a policy of pick and choose. Lawyers are threatening to disrupt the functioning of the country even as Zardari's political opponents outside Parliament have been boosted by the addition of Sharif in their ranks. Punjab is bound to remain a troublesome issue with the PML(N) Government still in power but any move to dislodge it may prove to be another flashpoint. Worse, given the state of the economy and rising extremism, the months ahead do not bode well for rising popular disaffection with the PPP Government. President Zardari will have little time to enjoy his Number One status.



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oppositional mindset," wrote analyst Cyril Almeida in *The Dawn*. "First Musharraf, then the judges—if Nawaz got his way, he would see no reason to stop making demands."

Zardari is also under pressure from the Americans—who had helped smoothen Musharraf out of power—to continue support for their 'war on terror', which Sharif had, at best, been ambivalent about. The renewed military operations in the tribal areas of the northwest known as Federally Administered Tribal Areas—which have displaced lakhs and led to hundreds of casualties—as well as the hardline statements coming from the PPP's de facto interior minister, Rehman Malik, and, indeed Zardari himself, indicate the minimum quid pro quo for American support. Even

ernments in three of the four provinces. In Punjab, where it is now in a shaky coalition with the PML(N), it has its governor who has the equivalent provincial powers of 58(2b). By March next year, the PPP also hopes to control the Senate. As the President, Zardari would wield the same powers that Musharraf had, and would, barring some catastrophe, out-

With extremist violence mounting and inflation spiralling, the political volatility will only deepen the crisis Pakistan faces.